

ber for joists, and to lay the beams in the houses which the kings of Judah had destroyed.

12 And the men acted faithfully in the work: and over them were appointed Jachath and 'Obadyahu, the Levites, of the sons of Merari; and Zechariah and Meshullam, of the sons of the Kehathites, to supervise; and every one of these Levites was skilful on instruments of music.

13 They were also over the bearers of burdens, and supervisors over all that did the work in every manner of service: and from the Levites there were also scribes, and officers, and gatekeepers.

14 And when they took out the money that had been brought into the house of the LORD, Chilkiyahu the priest found the book of the law of the LORD through the hand of Moses.

15 Then commenced Chilkiyahu and said to Shaphan the scribe, The book of the law have I found in the house of the LORD. And Chilkiyahu gave the book to Shaphan.

16 And Shaphan carried the book to the king, and brought the king also word back again, saying, All that was put in the hand of thy servants, have they truly done.

17 And they have taken out the money that was found in the house of the LORD, and have delivered it into the hand of the appointed overseers, and into the hand of those who overlook the workmen.

18 Then told Shaphan the scribe the king, saying, A book hath Chilkiyahu the priest given me. And Shaphan read in it before the king.

19 And it came to pass, when the king heard the words of the law, that he rent his clothes.

20 And the king commanded Chilkiyahu, and Achikam the son of Shaphan, and 'Abdon the son of Michah, and Shaphan the scribe, and 'Assayah a servant of the king's, saying,

21 Go ye, inquire of the LORD in my behalf, and in behalf of those that are left in Israel and in Judah, concerning the words of the book that hath been found; for great is the fury of the LORD that is poured out against us, because our fathers did not keep the word of the LORD, to do in accordance with all that is written in this book.

22 ¶ Then went Chilkiyahu with those

whom the king (had appointed), to Chuldah the prophetess, the wife of Shallum the son of Thokhath, the son of Chassrah, the keeper of the wardrobe;—now she dwelt in Jerusalem in the suburb;—and they spoke to her in that wise.

23 And she said unto them, Thus hath said the LORD the God of Israel, Say unto the man that hath sent you to me,

24 ¶ Thus hath said the LORD, Behold, I will bring evil upon this place, and upon its inhabitants, all the curses that are written in the book which they have read before the king of Judah;

25 Because they have forsaken me, and have burnt incense unto other gods, in order to provoke me to anger with all the works of their hands: therefore is my fury poured out upon this place, and it shall not be quenched.

26 And with respect to the king of Judah, who sendeth you to inquire of the LORD, thus shall ye say to him, Thus hath said the LORD the God of Israel, Concerning the words which thou hast heard;

27 Because thy heart was tender, and thou didst humble thyself before God, when thou heardest his words against this place, and against its inhabitants, and didst humble thyself before me, and rend thy clothes, and weep before me: I have also truly heard it, saith the LORD.

28 Behold, I will gather thee unto thy fathers, and thou shalt be gathered to thy graves in peace, and thy eyes shall not look on all the evil which I am bringing over this place, and over its inhabitants. And they brought the king word again.

29 ¶ And the king sent and gathered together all the elders of Judah and Jerusalem.

30 And the king went up into the house of the LORD, with all the men of Judah, and the inhabitants of Jerusalem, and the priests, and the Levites, and all the people, from the great to the small; and he read before their ears all the words of the book of the covenant which had been found in the house of the LORD.

31 And the king stood up on his stand, and he made a covenant before the LORD, to walk after the LORD, and to keep his commandments, and his testimonies, and his statutes, with all his heart and with all his

soul, to perform the words of the covenant that are written in this book.

32 And he caused to accede to it every one that was present in Jerusalem and Benjamin. And the inhabitants of Jerusalem acted in accordance with the covenant of God, the God of their fathers.

33 And Josiah removed all the abominations out of all the countries that belonged to the children of Israel, and caused all that were present in Israel to serve, even to serve the LORD their God. All his days did they not depart from following the LORD the God of their fathers.

CHAPTER XXXV.

1 ¶ And Josiah kept in Jerusalem the passover unto the LORD: and they slaughtered the passover-sacrifice on the fourteenth day of the first month.

2 And he placed the priests in their charges, and strengthened them for the service of the house of the LORD.

3 And he said unto the Levites that instructed all Israel, who were holy unto the LORD, Set the holy ark in the house which Solomon the son of David the king of Israel did build; you have not to carry it any more upon your shoulders: now serve the LORD your God, and his people Israel.

4 And prepare yourselves by your family divisions, according to your courses, after the written order of David the king of Israel, and after the written order of Solomon his son;

5 And stand in the holy place according to the divisions of the family divisions of your brethren the sons of the people, and after the division of the families of the Levites;

6 And slaughter the passover-sacrifice, and sanctify yourselves, and prepare it for your brethren, to do according to the word of the LORD by the hand of Moses.

7 ¶ And Josiah set apart for the sons of the people, of the flock, lambs and kids, all for the passover-sacrifices, for all that were present, to the number of thirty thousand, and of steers three thousand: these were of the king's property.

8 ¶ And his princes set apart (much) as a freewill gift for the people, for the priests, and for the Levites: Chilkiah, and Zechar-yahu, and Jechiel, the rulers of the house of

God, gave unto the priests for the passover-sacrifices two thousand and six hundred (lambs and kids), and three hundred steers.

9 And Conanyahu, and Shema'yahu and Nethanel, his brothers, and Chashabiyahu and Je'iel and Jozabad, the chiefs of the Levites, set apart unto the Levites for passover-sacrifices five thousand (lambs and kids), and five hundred steers.

10 ¶ So the service was established, and the priests stood on their station, and the Levites in their divisions, according to the king's command.

11 And they slaughtered the passover-sacrifice, and the priests sprinkled (the blood received) from their hands, and the Levites did the flaying.

12 And they removed the burnt-offerings to give them to the divisions of the family divisions of the sons of the people, to offer (them) unto the LORD, as it is written in the book of Moses. And so did they with the steers.

13 And they roasted the passover by the fire in accordance with the prescribed manner; but the holy offerings they seethed in pots, and in caldrons, and in pans, and divided them speedily among all the sons of the people.

14 And afterward they prepared for themselves, and for the priests; because the priests the sons of Aaron (were busied) in offering the burnt-offerings and the fat until night: therefore the Levites prepared for themselves and for the priests the sons of Aaron.

15 And the singers the sons of Assaph were on their station, according to the command of David, and Assaph, and Heman, and Jeduthun the king's seer; and the gate-keepers were at every gate: they had no need to depart from their service; because their brethren the Levites prepared for them.

16 So was established all the service of the LORD on the same day, to prepare the passover-sacrifice, and to offer burnt-offerings upon the altar of the LORD, according to the command of king Josiah.

17 And the children of Israel that were present prepared the passover-sacrifice at that time, and (kept) the feast of unleavened bread seven days.

18 And there was not holden any passover like this in Israel from the days of Samuel the prophet; and all the kings of Israel did not keep such a passover as Josiah kept, with

the priests, and the Levites, and all Judah and Israel that were present, and the inhabitants of Jerusalem.

19 ¶ In the eighteenth year of the reign of Josiah was this passover holden.

20 After all this, when Josiah had restored the temple, came up Necho the king of Egypt to fight against Karkemish by the Euphrates, and Josiah went out against him.

21 But he sent ambassadors to him, saying, What have I to do with thee, thou king of Judah? I come not against thee this day, but against the house^a wherewith I have war, and God hath commanded me to make haste: forbear thee from meddling with God who is with me, that he may not destroy thee.

22 Nevertheless did Josiah not turn his face away from him, but disguised^b himself, to fight with him, and hearkened not unto the words of Necho from the mouth of God; and he came to fight in the valley of Megiddo.

23 And the archers shot at king Josiah: and the king said to his servants, Carry me away; for I am sorely wounded.

24 And his servants carried him away out of that chariot, and conveyed him in the second chariot that he had; and they brought him to Jerusalem, and he died, and was buried in the sepulchres of his fathers. And all Judah and Jerusalem mourned for Josiah.

25 ¶ And Jeremiah lamented for Josiah; and all the singing men and the singing women spoke of Josiah in their lamentations to this day, and they instituted them as a custom in Israel: and, behold, they are written in the lamentations.

26 And the rest of the acts of Josiah, and his pious deeds, in accordance with what is written in the law of the LORD,

27 And his acts, the first and the last, behold, they are written in the book of the kings of Israel and Judah.

CHAPTER XXXVI.

1 ¶ And the people of the land took Jehoachaz the son of Josiah, and made him king in his father's stead in Jerusalem.

2 Twenty and three years old was Jö-

achaz when he became king, and three months did he reign in Jerusalem.

3 And the king of Egypt deposed him at Jerusalem, and imposed a fine on the land of a hundred talents of silver and a talent of gold.

4 And the king of Egypt made Elyakim his brother king over Judah and Jerusalem, and changed his name to Jehoyakim. And Jöachaz his brother did Necho take away, and bring him to Egypt.

5 ¶ Twenty and five years old was Jehoyakim when he became king, and eleven years did he reign in Jerusalem; and he did what is evil in the eyes of the LORD his God.

6 Against him came up Nebuchadnezzar the king of Babylon, and he bound him with fetters, to carry him away to Babylon.

7 And some of the vessels of the house of the LORD did Nebuchadnezzar carry to Babylon, and he placed them in his temple at Babylon.

8 And the rest of the acts of Jehoyakim, and his abominable deeds which he did, and that which was found concerning him, behold, they are written in the book of the kings of Israel and Judah. And Jehoyachin his son became king in his stead.

9 ¶ Eight^c years old was Jehoyachin when he became king, and three months and ten days did he reign in Jerusalem; and he did what is evil in the eyes of the LORD.

10 And with the expiration of the year did king Nebuchadnezzar send, and had him brought to Babylon, with the costly vessels of the house of the LORD: and he made Zedekiah his brother king over Judah and Jerusalem.

11 ¶ Twenty and one years old was Zedekiah when he became king, and eleven years did he reign in Jerusalem.

12 And he did what is evil in the eyes of the LORD his God: he humbled himself not before Jeremiah the prophet, according to the order of the Lord.

13 And also against king Nebuchadnezzar did he rebel, who had made him swear by God; but he stiffened his neck, and hardened his heart so as not to return unto the LORD the God of Israel.

^a i. e. The royal house—that of Assyria, with whom the Egyptians had frequent wars.

^b Zunz, "he persisted to fight."

^c In 2 Kings xxiv. 8, we have "eighteen." Rêdāk suggests that perhaps his father made him assistant ruler when he was only eight years old.